



CAREER IN DATA SCIENCE

DATA, THE RELIGION THAT IS ALSO SCIENCE, HAS ITS OWN SET OF COMMANDMENTS IF YOU WANT TO CONVERT.

Arnab Mukherjee
arnab@digit.in

Remember the Gold Rush of the 19th century? Well, maybe you don't, most probably because it was more than a couple of centuries ago. During that period, people travelled vast distances and even migrated completely to try their hand at prospecting for gold. Their only motivation was to strike a fortune and get a much better life going for themselves. Well, I wouldn't be too wrong to say that in the current day and age, data is that gold for almost all major corporations.

You won't actually find corporate employees going around the street hunting for data (they actually do and it's called surveys). There's no denying that major companies have completely changed the way they work since they have harnessed the power of data and analytics. Major decisions are being taken by companies as diverse as a software giant and a fast food retail chain by applying the same data techniques. With all this and more, it is evident that data science is a great career choice to make right now. But with automation looming large over the industry, is it really a safe option?

Look Ma, I'm a Scientist!

While data science and data scientists might be a buzzword, there is a

common dearth of awareness about what the role actually entails. Or if it is even an actual role at all. A broad definition of data science encompasses any kind of insights drawn from a large enough set of data. But that isn't helpful for someone who wants to be a data scientist. Without the knowledge of the role, they would essentially be flying hazy at best, blind at worst.

Mr. Arun Krishnan, Founder and CEO, nFactorial Analytical Sciences, says, "A data scientist is a combination of a computer scientist and a statistician. She has skills in Math, Statistics, Programming, Databases, Data Visualisation and Domain Knowledge, in addition to having good communication skills to tell a story with the data. A data analyst is probably someone with logical and statistical skills without the others mentioned above."

While the role of a data scientist does not bring much more information to light by itself, there are quite a few job roles that are related to the title. All of them might be called Data Scientists, but the roles can be quite different when compared. The following are not actual roles and only meant for getting an idea of possible tasks:

- **Data Analytics:** While Data science is well established as a separate field now, there are multiple companies that equate it with being a data analyst. Typical responsibilities in this role might involve pulling data

out of MySQL databases, becoming a master at Excel pivot tables, and producing basic data visualizations (for example, line and bar charts). This role is good to get a hang of things without much risk, and even experiment once in a while.

- **Data Wrangler:** Medium to small companies that are making the switch to a better data infrastructure, due to increased traffic and consequently increased data, have the demand for a role like this. This role usually involves setting up the infrastructure along with providing analysis and is suitable for someone with a software engineering background. This one's for the risk takers who want an opportunity to shine in this field.
- **Data Jedi:** Data drives these companies and data is their product. Usually, in such an organisation, the degree of machine learning and statistics involved is high. As a result, this type of a role is ideal for someone with a strong academic background in those fields with a passionate desire to continue down the same road.
- **Data Consultant:** Companies with a reasonable stake in data, but not data companies themselves, are usually on the lookout for this role. When joining a company like this as a data scientist, you will probably be a part of an established team of data scientists.